

2 Status, Foreign Policy, and Revisionism

Rising powers have incentives to pursue policies that express demands for limited changes in the status quo distribution of resources while signaling support for status quo rules, norms, and institutions. But sometimes they pursue policies that express demands for much more radical change. They take steps that aim at protesting, delegitimizing, or overthrowing status quo norms, rules, and institutions, and they fail to behave in ways that could make distributive gains easier and cheaper. As I showed in Chapter 1, these radical revisionist policy combinations are puzzling and particularly dangerous and destabilizing.

In this chapter, I develop a theoretical explanation for shifts from distributive to radical revisionist policy combinations in rising great powers. My account builds directly on Gilpin's insight that obstructed demands for "incremental" change can push rising states to demand deeper changes. But I part ways with Gilpin in two important ways. First, I argue that it is not obstructed economic and security ambitions but rather the appearance of permanently obstructed status demands that push states toward radical revisionist policy combinations. Second, I appeal to social psychological and domestic political mechanisms to explain how permanently obstructed status ambitions contribute first to individual demands for policies that reject status quo norms, rules, and institutions and then to state behavior that expresses these preferences.

My argument, in short, is that status immobility unleashes social psychological and political forces that push rising states toward radical revisionism. The belief that the rising state's status claims cannot be accommodated can produce preferences among individuals for policies that reject the status quo order. The more prominent the idea of status immobility is in the elite beliefs and foreign policy discourse of a rising state, the harder it is for moderate leaders to justify policies that participate in status quo institutions, follow status quo norms and rules, and cooperate with states identified as defenders of the order. This dynamic creates political advantages for hardliners, who can influence foreign

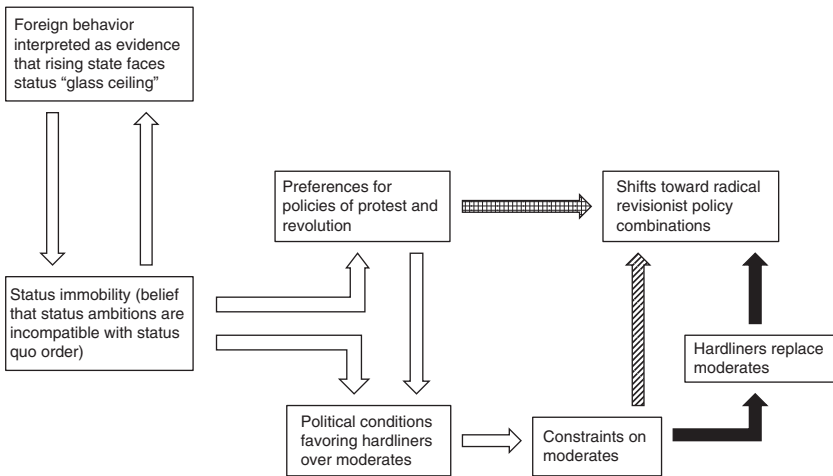


Figure 2.1 Status Immobility and Foreign Policy Change

policy even when they are not in power by pressuring moderate incumbents or by contributing to their political defeat. The result is a set of processes that push toward deeply (and sub-optimally) aggressive and provocative policy combinations. Figure 2.1 – to which I refer throughout the discussion below – summarizes these causal sequences.

The argument also complements the constructivist and domestic accounts reviewed in the previous chapter. Normative distance may well contribute to rising state dissatisfaction with status quo norms, rules, and institutions, but I argue that the appearance of permanently obstructed status claims can contribute to the dominance of distant visions of order in rising states. This is clearly not the only possible source of ideological differences between rising states and hegemony, but I show in Chapter 5 that it helps explain the rise to prominence and ultimate victory of Hitler's vision in the early 1930s. Similarly, my argument is consistent with domestic stories that involve rhetorical and political entrapment. But it clarifies an important ambiguity related to these approaches by proposing beliefs and discourses about status immobility as one condition that favors hardliners over moderates in rhetorical and political contests over policy.

The chapter proceeds as follows. I first define status and explain why states – especially rising states – want it and how they acquire it. I then introduce the concept of status immobility – the belief that a state's status

ambitions have been permanently and unjustly obstructed. I develop the argument that status immobility produces shifts toward radical revisionism in two steps. First, I draw on insights from social psychology to argue that status immobility can cause individual demands for policies that reject status quo rules, norms, and institutions. Second, I argue that widespread beliefs and prominent discourses that the state faces a condition of status immobility change political conditions in ways that strengthen hardliners and weaken moderates. The chapter concludes by laying out my strategy for assessing the theory in light of evidence from the behavior of historical rising powers.

Rising Powers and Status Ambitions

Status refers to an actor's position within a social hierarchy. It may mean either membership in a highly regarded group or category of actors (like the "Big Ten") or rank within a group. Unlike other resources like wealth or power, status has to be recognized by other actors in order to be experienced as real. When an actor seeks a particular status, this entails an effort to achieve the markers of that status – the consensually valued characteristics that serve as prerequisites for membership – in order to convince others to behave in ways that signal that the status claim is legitimate.¹

For example, an individual seeking the status of "professor" would go about accruing the markers of that status by achieving the characteristics of a professor and behaving like a professor. This might involve standing up and lecturing in a classroom twice a week. But if other actors do not respond appropriately – if students, for instance, refuse to pay attention or show up at all – then the aspiring professor will not experience the status as real.

This point is worth restating in more general terms. Whereas other kinds of ambitions can be satisfied unilaterally (as long as an actor is capable and committed enough) status ambitions are different. Their satisfaction depends upon the willingness of other actors to accommodate or recognize them by behaving in ways that ratify the claim.²

¹ For recent definitions, see Dafoe, Renshon, and Huth (2014), pp. 374–375; Larson, Paul, and Wohlforth (2014), p. 7; Neumann and de Carvalho (2015), pp. 4–7.

² The literature on recognition in international politics is concerned with the same fundamental issues as is the literature on status, but it differs in two primary ways: its self-conscious focus on the *performance* of identity claims, as opposed to the acquisition of status markers or consensually valued resources, and its attentiveness to the consequences of misrecognition (as opposed to status inconsistency, dissatisfaction, or anxiety) for foreign policy. See Ringmar (1996), Murray (2010), Lindemann (2010), Ringmar (2012), Daase, Fehl, Geis, and Kolliarakis (2015), and Lindemann and Ringmar (2016).

There is substantial evidence from social psychology and other fields that human beings identify with groups and care not just about their own individual status but also about the status of the groups that make up their social identities.³ Understanding why this is so – and in particular why individuals care about the status of the state with which they identify – is critically important to the argument that I develop later in this chapter. There are three potential explanations.

First, it is likely that – in some contexts – groups with higher status provide the individuals that identify with them with better life chances. Attending a university with higher status provides certain material advantages; so does identifying (and being identified) as a member of a high status ethnic group.

Some scholars have analyzed the role of status in world politics primarily from this materialist perspective. Gilpin, for instance, suggested that the status of hegemon confers on its holder the right to order the international system in ways that benefit itself above other states. Others argue that high status increases power, influence, credibility, or coercive leverage, and thus that it has a positive effect on a state's welfare and security.⁴

But there is no reason to presume that status matters to states primarily because of its material significance, or to take this notion as a default theoretical starting point. For one thing, the claim that status boosts influence, credibility, or coercive leverage has never been demonstrated empirically in the context of international politics. It is, at this stage of the research program, no more than an assumption.⁵ Moreover, a common finding of research on status in IR is that its pursuit often comes at the *expense* of welfare or security.⁶ And individuals seem to care about the

³ See Frank (1985); Goethals and Darley (1987); Berger and Zelditch (1998); Berger et al. (1998); Loch et al. (2001).

⁴ Gilpin (1981); Dafoe, Renshon, and Huth (2014); Renshon (2016, 2017); Sambanis, Skaperdas, and Wohlforth (2015).

⁵ Renshon (2017) asserts that status has instrumental value in the context of international politics and that this means that we should build theories about status-seeking on rationalist or strategic foundations, rather than by appealing to what he calls “weak” mechanisms related to frustration or other emotions. But it is striking that he provides no evidence that the former claim is true. Indeed, the way that he discusses his experimental results (Chapter 3) leads to the interpretation that status concerns reduce the quality of decision-making; there is no attempt to establish a link between status and outcomes like success in coercive bargaining in the quantitative section of the book (Chapters 4 and 5); and in each of the four historical cases that he analyzes (pre-World War I Germany, Russia during the July Crisis, Great Britain during the Suez Crisis, and Egypt's intervention in Yemen beginning in 1962), status-seeking did not lead to any concrete instrumental advantage, but rather to disaster (Chapters 6 and 7). Moreover, Mercer (2017) has recently provided compelling theoretical and empirical reasons to think that, far from having instrumental value, status is an illusion that states pursue at their peril.

⁶ See Murray (2010); Ward (2013); Wolf (2014).

status of groups with which they identify even when this has no plausible effect on their material welfare. Whether the Yankees win the World Series in any given year has material significance only for the club's employees and for people whose businesses might benefit from a long playoff run. Fans nonetheless remain deeply emotionally invested in the performance of their team. If the status of an athletic team matters to human beings for reasons that have almost nothing to do with material welfare or instrumental value, then it makes little sense to assume that a state's status is primarily significant because of its utility for the pursuit of other objectives.

A second explanation is that the status of a group is significant for the self-esteem of the individuals that identify with it. This is the position of much social psychological research – especially the body of it known as social identity theory (SIT). Developers and users of the SIT framework have demonstrated experimentally that individuals exhibit ingroup bias, even when group membership is minimally constituted and even when favoring members of the ingroup over members of the outgroup has no plausible link to any materially significant outcome.⁷ The implication of these findings is that group status matters because it influences how individuals feel about themselves. Being a member of a respected group generates positive emotions like pride; being a member of a disrespected group generates negative emotions like shame and, under some conditions, anger and frustration.

From this perspective, individuals care about the status of the state because the status of the state influences their self-esteem. This, of course, is not true of all individuals all the time – some people will simply not spend much time thinking about what it means to be American or French or Canadian, and others may actively object to such categorizations. But some people do identify strongly as members of states – this is a defining feature of nationalists. And for these individuals – according to the insights of social psychologists – the status of the state is important not (or not mostly) because of its material significance, but because of its significance for identity and self-esteem.⁸

The third reason that the status of a state might matter to an individual is related to the second, but it applies specifically to leaders: status might be important because of its significance for domestic political legitimacy.

⁷ On SIT, see Tajfel (1978a, 1978b, 1982); Tajfel and Turner (1979); and Hogg and Abrams (1988).

⁸ For a review of social psychological perspectives on nationalism, see Druckman (1994). This perspective is common within parts of the IR status literature, most notably in the work of Larson and Shevchenko (2010, 2014), but also in recent work on stigma and social hierarchy (Zarakol [2011], and Adler-Nissen [2014]).

The link between status and the legitimacy of a leader runs through the preferences of nationalists and the nature of predominant identity narratives or claims: if, as suggested above, nationalists care about the status of the state and prefer higher to lower status, or are attached to a particular understanding of what status the state deserves, then demonstrating a commitment to raising or maintaining the state's status is critical for any leader at least partially dependent on their support. Presiding over a decline in status or a failure to satisfy ambitions for higher status leaves the leader vulnerable to charges of having failed to secure the state's rightful place in the international system – which may undermine his or her legitimacy and position.

Status may matter to states for all three of these reasons. Yet the second and third are critical to the argument I develop below. If status were *only* important because of its value in terms of wealth and security, then it could be bought and sold without much difficulty. A state whose status ambitions seemed incompatible with the status quo order could be compensated in other ways. It is the emotional and domestic political significance of status that makes this difficult and that makes status distinct from other kinds of resources. Appearing to bargain away a claim to equal or superior status might be seen as unacceptable for reasons that have nothing to do with welfare or security, which may make it a dangerous proposition for a leader. In short, status may indeed make a state wealthier and more secure; but privileging this understanding of status' role in IR is unwarranted and leaves one with an anemic view of its potential consequences for foreign policy.

Establishing that status-seeking often motivates foreign policy has been one of the most important achievements of the growing literature on status in international politics.⁹ This scholarship has identified status-seeking as the driver of policies and outcomes that include among others the initiation of major war, great power rivalry, construction of certain kinds of weapons, attempts to join or reform international organizations, and involvement in peacekeeping and humanitarian missions around the world. Status is obviously not the *only* resource that motivates states, but it is a prominent and underappreciated one. And it holds the potential to help us understand otherwise unintelligible behaviors, like Germany's

⁹ Thucydides (1972), I: 76, acknowledged the status motive, as did Hobbes (1985), p. 185, Machiavelli (1996), p. 219, and Rousseau (1991), p. 48. See also Slomp (1990), p. 566; and see Markey (1999, 2000) on status in the thought of classical authors. But with some notable exceptions (for instance, a short-lived research program that began in the 1970s, Gilpin's [1981] invocation of "prestige" in *War and Change*, and a short discussion in Nicholas Onuf's [1989], Kindle location 5310–5538, foundational exposition of constructivism), the concept has not attracted sustained attention from IR scholars until recently.

obsession with building battleships before World War I or Norway's insistence on "punching above its weight" in world politics.¹⁰

Clearly not all states' foreign policies are equally concerned with status-seeking. Some seem deeply concerned – like contemporary China – while others – like, say, Canada or Switzerland – seem not to care as much. This is not a simple matter of power: small states sometimes have foreign policies that are deeply concerned with issues of standing.¹¹ The literature on status in IR has not developed a comprehensive account of variation in the salience of status concerns, and I do not do so in this book either.¹²

What previous scholarship *has* established, though, is that status is often an especially salient concern for states whose material capabilities are rising. Increasing wealth and military power make a rising state more like established high status powers in significant ways, which prompts people who identify with the riser to expect – and demand – convergence in terms of standing, influence, and rights as well. This dynamic is at the core of claims by contemporary Chinese elites for a renegotiated pattern of relations between Beijing and Washington: China's growing economy and improved military mean that it deserves to be treated like an equal, rather than like a subordinate regional player.¹³

But status attribution or recognition often lags behind increases in economic and military power.¹⁴ This observation – which is at the core of Gilpin's framework in *War and Change* – explains why rising states sometimes seem so preoccupied with their place in the world. Rising

¹⁰ For a review, see Dafoe, Renshon, and Huth (2014). On status and conflict, see Lebow (2008), (2010b); Wohlforth (2009); Larson and Shevchenko (2010); and Onea (2014). Others have argued that status partially explains why states build nuclear weapons (Hummel 2016), battleships (Murray 2010), and aircraft carriers (Ross 2009; Pu and Schweller 2014). On status and international organizations, see Larson and Shevchenko (2010, 2014a); Paul and Shankar (2014); Heimann (2014); and Pouliot (2014). On status and involvement in peacekeeping operations and humanitarian efforts, see Suzuki (2008), and in the context of Norwegian foreign policy, Graeger (2015) and de Carvalho and Lie (2015).

¹¹ On small-state status-seeking, see de Carvalho and Neumann (2015).

¹² Renshon (2017) has recently made a start by arguing that the salience of status concerns is fundamentally a matter of unmet expectations, though there remain a large number of outstanding questions.

¹³ The most prominent articulation of this argument is in Gilpin's *War and Change* (1981). More recently, see Renshon (2016, 2017) and Volgy et al. (2014). Though Renshon attributes the link between increasing capabilities and status ambitions to a combination of perceived opportunity and grievance (due to being denied the status appropriate to the state's "asset level"), Mercer's (2017) recent critique implies that it may have more to do with emotional psychology: increasing capabilities may generate pride that then translates into heightened expectations about the state's status. On Chinese status expectations, see Deng (2008).

¹⁴ On the "stickiness" of attributed status, see Renshon (2017), Chapter 5.

status expectations result from rising (or apparently rising) material capabilities, but status does not follow automatically. It has to be granted through acts of accommodation – actions by high status states that confer on the rising power particular rights and privileges that are associated with the status it seeks. Status expectations can outpace acts of accommodation for many reasons. Established powers might not understand the nature of the rising power's demands; institutional inertia could delay accommodation; or – most simply – the established power might be uncomfortable acknowledging that the rising power deserves the status, rights, and privileges that it claims.¹⁵

This should not be taken as an argument that rising power is the *only* source of concerns about status. Explaining the origins of status ambitions involves, at root, explaining the origins of the way that people imagine their state's place in the world. This process is clearly driven by much more than changes in material capabilities: other factors – like representations of national history, collective understandings of identity, and the idiosyncratic personalities and choices of leaders – also matter. My claim is simply that – whatever else might be at work – rising power often drives rising status expectations. This means that the theoretical dynamics that I develop below are particularly relevant for understanding the foreign policies of rising powers.

Whatever their source, status expectations that outpace accommodation result in the condition of *status inconsistency* or *status dissatisfaction*.¹⁶ Status inconsistency is politically and psychologically uncomfortable – individuals feel that the state with which they identify deserves more respect than it gets, and may also feel that their leaders are failing to secure it. Leaders, for their part, may feel pressure to address concerns about the state's status through policies aimed at securing recognition from other states. The conventional wisdom in the IR status literature is that policies intended to correct a condition of status inconsistency or dissatisfaction typically entail conflict, violence, and war.¹⁷ But this is not

¹⁵ See Wohlforth (2014) on uncertainty about status ambitions and Onega (2014) on the dominant state's disinclination to recognize the riser's claims. Mercer (2017) suggests that reluctance to recognize claims to higher status may also be driven by psychological mechanisms that bias actors toward discounting the achievements of rivals. On accommodation more broadly, see Paul (2016).

¹⁶ Lenski (1954). Status inconsistency has often been linked to demands for social change and violence. See Galtung (1964); Stryker and Macke (1978); and Gould (2003). On status dissatisfaction, see Renshon (2017). I use status inconsistency and status dissatisfaction interchangeably.

¹⁷ The link between status inconsistency and war originated with Galtung (1964), and spawned a large quantitative literature during the 1970s, 1980s, and 1990s (East 1972; Wallace 1971, 1973; Ray 1974; Gochman 1980; Volgy and Mayhall 1995). More recently, see Wohlforth (2009); Volgy et al. (2014); and Renshon (2016, 2017).

always true. The way in which a demand for status influences policy depends upon the particular markers associated with the aspirational status category, and these are social constructions that vary across time and space.¹⁸ A state aspiring to great power status may need to fight and win wars, but only if demonstrating the ability to do so is understood as a prerequisite for membership in the great power club. In different contexts, the markers of great power status have included the possession of particular kinds of weapons systems (battleships around the turn of the twentieth century; nuclear weapons after 1945; and aircraft carriers today), the possession and administration of colonial territory (until the post-1945 era), and certain civilizational and institutional characteristics (which have varied over time). States seeking this particular status will do so by pursuing a mix of policies intended to increase the similarity between themselves and existing great powers along all relevant dimensions. Status-seeking only entails violence to the extent that violence is necessary to achieve status markers.¹⁹

The record of Japanese status-seeking after the Meiji restoration is a useful example. As I detail in Chapter 4, Japan aspired to membership in the club of Western great powers that included Great Britain, France, and the United States (and at various times Germany, Russia, Italy, and Austria-Hungary). Achieving this status entailed a mix of policies. Some of these involved violent conflict, such as the wars against China and Russia that earned Japan its first overseas possessions. But status-seeking also involved efforts to reform Japanese social and political institutions to bring them in line with Western norms, as well as a concerted effort to participate in the management of the post-World War I order by joining the League of Nations as a permanent member of the League Council. All of this was in large part motivated by a desire to achieve for Japan the same rights and privileges afforded other great powers.²⁰

The Japanese efforts highlight another important point. Status-seeking itself does not push states to adopt radical revisionist policy combinations. Indeed, to the extent that seeking status motivates states to participate more deeply in status quo institutions and ratify (by their behavior) status

¹⁸ For example, see Towns (2010) for a thorough account of the changing function of gender norms as markers of status in world politics, and the varying ways in which this influenced policy toward women in states positioned differently in the international hierarchy.

¹⁹ See, for instance, Barnhart (2016) on the role of collective understandings about the value of colonial territory in explanations in constituting imperial competition as a response to status anxiety among late nineteenth-century European powers.

²⁰ See also Ward (2013).

quo norms, it actually strengthens the normative element of the status quo order.²¹ It is, in the conceptual vocabulary introduced in Chapter 1, a form of distributive revisionism.

Status Immobility

Recent scholarship on status in IR has made important contributions to our understanding of the ways in which states seek status and some of the links between status dynamics and conflict. It has also left important questions unanswered. One of the most significant relates to the consequences of persistently denied status claims. Since the satisfaction of status claims depends upon recognition by other states, this raises the possibility that persistent denials could convince elites and others in a rising state that their status ambitions are fundamentally inconsistent with the status quo order. I call this pessimism about the prospects of securing recognition *status immobility*.

Status immobility refers to the belief that a state's status ambitions face an obstacle that is fundamental to the status quo order and cannot be overcome from inside of it. Two parts of this conceptual definition require clarification. First, the concept does not refer to an objective condition. Certainly objective conditions are significant – the behavior of other states, for instance, is an important source of information about the possibility of achieving membership in an aspirational status club. But what really matters is how individuals and groups within the rising state interpret international conditions and foreign behavior. This means that beliefs about the severity of the obstacle the rising state faces can vary across actors *within* the rising state.

Second, status immobility refers to the appearance of obstacles that originate within the political, normative, or institutional structure of the status quo order; it does not refer to obstacles related to the incompetence or unwillingness to invest of the status-seeker. The key difference is that status immobility involves the notion that exclusion from the aspirational status club is *unjust*.²² In this sense, status immobility can be understood as a status “glass ceiling.” The problem is not that the rising state has not yet accumulated the requisite markers of status and thus does not deserve membership; it is instead that the state *does* deserve membership, but other states seem fundamentally unwilling to treat it as a full member of the club.

²¹ See also Wohlforth (2015), pp. 149–152.

²² For an important treatment of justice in international relations, see Welch (1993).

The processes through which perceptions and discourses of status immobility arise are complex and multiple. They are rooted, in part, in actions by other states – especially by established members of elite status clubs – that seem to signal a firm commitment to refusing the rising power's claims to higher standing. Put more concretely, foreign behavior may contribute to the emergence of beliefs and the production of discourses about status immobility when it seems to deny the status-seeker rights and privileges claimed as inherent to the aspirational status, and when it seems to reflect a basic disposition against recognizing the rising power as an equal, rather than a simple conflict of interest in some specific context. These two elements are worth unpacking at more length.

First, for an act to be interpreted as evidence of status immobility, it needs to appear to be an act of status denial. To understand what this means, it is helpful to think of status as a role identity associated with a bundle of rights and privileges: “great power” status, for instance, is an identity that has made it possible for states to whom that identity adheres to legitimately take certain actions – like intervening in their near abroad or possessing particular kinds of weapons – that would be illegitimate for other kinds of states. There are, in other words, certain rights and privileges – which are historically contingent and have evolved over time – to which only states in the “great power” club have legitimate access.²³

In concrete terms, then, an act of status denial is an act by one state that seems to deny that another state has access to a right that it claims as part of a claim to a particular status. The US Navy's freedom of navigation (FON) operational assertion program nicely illustrates the sort of act that might be interpreted as evidence of status denial. Under the FON program, the navy sails warships through maritime zones in which other states have claimed rights to restrict navigation that exceed the limits set out in the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea. In other words, FON operational assertions assert the right to freedom of navigation while signaling a denial of the target state's right to restrict navigation. When the target state's claim is implicated in a broader claim to standing – as it arguably is in the case of Chinese claims to a sphere of influence in East Asia and the South China Sea – an operational assertion may seem to be an act that denies not only the right but also the associated claim to status.²⁴

Second, in order to be interpreted as evidence of status immobility, an act of status denial has to seem to reflect a fundamental inability or

²³ For consistent treatments, see Bull (1977), pp. 207 and 212; Simpson (2004), pp. 68–71; Suzuki (2008), p. 47; Heimann (2014); Larson, Paul, and Wohlforth (2014), p. 10; Neumann (2014); and Paul (2016), p. 5.

²⁴ On the FON program, see Etzioni (2015).

unwillingness to accommodate the rising power. Not all acts of status denial are equally easy for observers who identify with the rising state to assimilate into a narrative about the basic injustice of the status quo order. Some may seem to be one-off consequences of circumstance, or they can be explained away as nothing more than the result of the bargaining and haggling that characterizes the typical nature of international politics.

Two characteristics make acts of status denial easier to see and characterize as evidence that a state faces a condition of status immobility. First, an act that seems to be part of a *pattern* is easier to interpret as evidence that the status quo is unjust than is an act that seems to come out of the blue. This is an obvious but important point, and it implies that perceptions of status immobility take time to emerge and are path-dependent – if leaders or elites have characterized foreign behavior as an act of status denial in the past, it will be easier for them or others to interpret a new act of status denial as reflective of a disposition against treating the state justly.

Second, acts of status denial are easier to interpret as evidence of status immobility when they can reasonably be presented as the consequence of a salient structural condition that prevents the state from being treated fairly.²⁵ This, too, is a straightforward point: an act of status denial is more likely to seem like a reflection of systemic injustice when it appears to be driven by a deep, difficult-to-change feature of the international environment than when it seems explicable as a result of the disposition of a particular leader or the nature of a temporary set of circumstances. When acts of status denial can be attributed by observers to factors like inflexible alliance commitments, discrimination based on identity cleavages, or institutional arrangements, they are likely to contribute to pessimism about the possibility of achieving the state's status ambitions without a drastic change in the character of the status quo order.

But acts of status denial merely provide the raw material out of which beliefs about and discourses of status immobility emerge. The ways in which leaders and other political elites publicly interpret the meaning of what happens abroad is also important. This may have more to do with short-term political incentives than it does with genuine beliefs about the injustice of the international status quo, and it is heavily influenced by the rhetorical and political resources elites have available to them as a result of the way that they (and their predecessors) have interpreted the state's history. A leader in a status-seeking state might, for instance, have an

²⁵ See Zarakol (2011), Kindle locations 2428–2610, for a discussion of the ways in which social conditions can seem to impose insurmountable obstacles to advancement.

incentive to publicly make sense of some crisis or diplomatic defeat as evidence of a discriminatory disposition on the part of other states in order to deflect attention from the incompetence or overreaching of the government. And doing so might be easier if the allegedly obstructionist state seems to have a record of behaving in ways that seem unjust, unfair, or discriminatory to the status-seeker. This means that the process by which status immobility becomes prominent in any state is path-dependent. This complication has methodological implications to which I return at the end of the chapter.

This discussion raises a puzzle: why do established powers not attempt to accommodate the status claims of rising powers and thereby short-circuit or minimize the negative consequences that – I argue below – emerge from the production of status immobility? This is an important question, in part because it has implications for the ability to distinguish – in practice – status immobility theory from standard realist accounts of conflict driven by power transitions. These might contend that established powers deny the status claims of rising powers because accommodation is incompatible with a commitment to opposing or containing the expansion of the rising power's material capabilities or influence, and, as a result, that accommodation threatens the established power's welfare or security.²⁶ Thus conflict over status is inevitable, but epiphenomenal: it is merely a product of conflict over security or wealth, and thus does not merit attention in its own right.

It is worth taking very seriously the possibility that accommodation failure is nothing more than the consequence of a commitment to the material containment of a rising power, and that conflict over status is reducible to conflict over wealth or security. This view implies that accommodation and containment represent opposite poles along a continuum of policy options available to established powers confronting rising powers – thus, to choose containment is to reject accommodation (and thus commit to status denial), and vice versa.

But accommodation and containment are better understood as positions along *two distinct* dimensions of policy. Accommodation refers to behavior that signals to the riser that it has legitimate access to some claimed right or set of rights associated with a particular status category. Status denial refers to actions that signal the opposite. Containment, on the other hand, refers to actions aimed at halting or restricting the expansion of a rising power's material capabilities. Its opposite is retrenchment: the reduction of security commitments and the resultant

²⁶ See Paul and Shankar (2014) and Lobell (2016) for arguments about security concerns as an obstacle to accommodation.

(at least tacit) acquiescence to the rising power's growing material power and influence.²⁷

These are separate analytical dimensions, and established powers can, and sometimes do, adopt policy orientations that approximate all four possible combinations. This implies that status denial is not always caused by a commitment to containment. For instance, I show in Chapter 4 that Western policy toward interwar Japan combined status denial – in the form of behavior that seemed to reject Tokyo's claims to a variety of status-related rights in world politics – with a refusal to materially oppose the expansion of Japanese power and influence in East Asia. Similarly, I argue in Chapter 5 that the Allied powers pursued a combination of status denial and retrenchment toward interwar Germany – they acted in ways that seemed to reject Berlin's claims to the rights of a great power, but they also refused to contain its growing material capabilities. In neither of these cases were acts of status denial caused by the pursuit of policies aimed at containment.

In fact, acts of status denial can be driven by a variety of dynamics. Established powers may suffer from their own status anxieties – perhaps exacerbated by the nature of the rising power's demands – which might make acts of accommodation difficult; domestic political obstacles unrelated to status concerns might prevent accommodation in some cases; and established power leaders may even simply fail to correctly perceive the nature of the rising power's demands. The upshot is that even if acts of status denial are sometimes caused by the commitment to containment, the origins of status immobility are separate from – and thus not reducible to – conflict over power and security. The sources of status immobility are diverse.

Ultimately it is the consequences of status immobility – not its causes – that are central to my argument in this book. Analysts of status in world politics have thus far not developed a consistent and satisfying account of what happens when a state's status ambitions are obstructed. The most common argument is that obstructed status claims lead states to abandon peaceful status-seeking strategies in favor of geopolitically competitive or violent ones.²⁸ There are several problems with this proposition. First, geopolitically competitive forms of status-seeking often precede perceptions of status immobility, for the simple reason that military power, territory, and economic resources are common markers of status.²⁹

²⁷ On containment, see Art (2003), pp. 111–120; on retrenchment, see MacDonald and Parent (2011).

²⁸ Larson and Shevchenko (2010, 2014a, 2014b); Murray (2010); Wolf (2014); Lee (2016).

²⁹ See, for instance, Barnhart (2016), Volgy et al. (2014), Renshon (2016).

Thus geopolitical competition is often the result of an attempt to achieve higher status, rather than a response to the perception that doing so is impossible.

Second, in most cases status-seeking – even vigorous and violent status-seeking – *strengthens* the normative and institutional elements of the status quo, and thus the foundation of the privileged position of its defenders. It has this effect because – as the Japanese example briefly discussed above shows – it accepts and ratifies the legitimacy of existing markers of high status.³⁰ Even Germany's deeply conflictual effort to catch up with Great Britain in terms of battleships and colonies cannot but have signaled that Germany accepted the legitimacy of battleships and colonies as valued attributes – the same valued attributes that constituted Great Britain as the state at the top of the global hierarchy.

A state facing a situation in which its status ambitions appeared *incompatible* with the status quo order – or an individual who believed the state faced a status “glass ceiling” – would thus confront a dilemma: policies aimed at status-seeking by acquiring consensually valued characteristics might simultaneously be futile and reproductive of the unjust order. They may, as a result, be doubly unattractive. In the next section, I propose instead that status immobility pushes toward policy responses that protest, delegitimize, or overthrow the normative foundation of the status quo order.

A third problem with existing treatments of state responses to concerns about status is that they almost invariably treat states as if they were people, which leaves the mechanisms at the heart of these accounts ambiguous. One prominent approach, for instance, has been to take the insights of social identity theory – a social psychological framework that is intended to explain how individuals manage status anxiety originating in group membership – and use them to explain how *states* manage status anxiety.³¹ But individuals within states may hold very different ideas about what the state's status ambitions should be, how important they are relative to other goals, and how likely they are to be achieved within the bounds of the status quo order. In order to link beliefs about status “glass ceilings” to foreign policy, we need to incorporate status dynamics into a model that takes seriously the politics of making policy. The theoretical framework that I develop in the next section does this by proposing that status immobility has the potential to influence policy not only by motivating leaders but also by changing the balance of power between moderates and hardliners inside states.

³⁰ Lebow (2008), p. 67; Suzuki (2008), p. 60; Zarakol (2011), Kindle location 2234.

³¹ See Larson and Shevchenko (2003, 2010, 2014a).

Status Immobility, Demands to Reject the Status Quo Order, and Foreign Policy

This book's central argument is that status immobility produces social psychological and political forces that push rising states toward adopting policies that reject – rather than seek to adjust or rise within – the status quo order. There are two important elements of this argument. The first is an account – rooted in insights from social psychology – of the origins of individual preferences for policies that reject the status quo order. Put simply, the perception of persistent, unjust status denial can produce demands for actions aimed at overthrowing, withdrawing from, or protesting status quo rules and institutions. These dynamics are most likely to affect those who identify most strongly with the group – which, in the context of international politics, means strong nationalists. Thus, the first element of the theory establishes its micro-foundations: a social psychological link between perceptions of persistent status denial and an interest (especially among nationalists) in policies aimed at rejecting international order.

Of course, foreign policy will not always reflect the preferences of frustrated nationalists. Leaders have competing interests to balance, and may be more sensitive to the (domestic and international) costs and risks that rejectionist policies entail. Thus, the second element of the theory draws on insights from research on the politics of legitimation to build an account that links preferences for rejectionist policies to concrete policy change. The argument is that widespread beliefs about or discourses of status immobility constitute a domestic political resource that benefits actors with hardline foreign policy preferences. It can be invoked to weaken incumbents – especially if they prefer to pursue moderate policies – and to strengthen the proponents of aggressive policies, regardless of where aggressive preferences originate. And anticipation of these effects on their political survival can push moderate incumbents to pursue rejectionist policies against their own better judgment. Thus the social psychological consequences of status immobility can be harnessed by political entrepreneurs to effect foreign policy change and advance their own interests, even if they themselves evidence no great concern with the state's status. This dynamic makes the state's foreign policy more aggressive and more reflective of the preferences of those frustrated nationalists demanding rejection of the status quo.

Status Immobility and the Social Psychology of Rejection

Previous scholarship has drawn upon social identity theory to derive three logics of identity management, or strategic responses to low state status.

The standard model distinguishes between *mobility* (emulating the values and institutions of the members of the elite club to join its ranks), *creativity* (altering the markers associated with membership in the elite club), and *competition* (attempting to equal or outdo a higher status state in the areas on which its dominance is based). This is a valuable taxonomy, but it is incomplete. Each of these responses to status anxiety depends, in the end, on the recognition of existing members of the elite club; each also at least implicitly accepts and therefore ratifies and reproduces the prevailing institutions and rules that constitute the elite club as elite. This is most obviously true for mobility, but it is also true for creativity – which aims at the reform of the status quo from within – and competition – which takes for granted that the advantaged position of the dominant actor has a legitimate basis and merely seeks to beat the dominant actor at its own game.³²

What the taxonomy is missing is an account of how actors respond when gaining status through these three avenues seems to face an unjust, externally imposed, and insuperable obstacle. What is needed, in other words, is an account of how actors respond to status *immobility*. I introduce a new logic of identity management – the logic of rejection – that addresses this neglected dilemma.

First, though, a note on what I mean by “logic of identity management” is in order. I depart slightly from the standard model (which treats mobility, creativity, and competition as strategies from which unitary states choose) and define a “logic of identity management” in international politics as a way of dealing with low state status that an *individual* who identifies with that state may pursue or promote in response to the way in which the individual understands the international social conditions that the state faces. Two individuals may at the same time promote two different responses – one may advocate that the state compete for status; the other may promote creativity because competition seems infeasible or unwisely provocative.

In terms more familiar to students of international politics, a logic of identity management is analogous to a grand strategy – while a grand strategy is a theory about how a state can secure its material existence and welfare, a logic of identity management is a theory about how a state can best secure its identity and status. And just as individuals often promote different grand strategies based on their varying ideas about factors like the nature of the national interest or the utility of force, individuals also

³² Part of the problem with this taxonomy is that it is based on a mistranslation of social identity theory. See Ward (forthcoming).

promote different logics of identity management based on their varying ideas about the international social conditions the state faces.

The familiar identity management strategies of *mobility*, *competition*, and *creativity* are all based on the logic of recognition. They can only resolve a condition of status dissatisfaction by convincing relevant others to recognize the rising state's claims, and their pursuit has centripetal force: each of these responses, in an important sense, accepts (thereby ratifying and perpetuating) the rules, institutions, and social hierarchy that constitute the status quo. Mobility does this by emulating consensually valued cultural and institutional forms; competition by tacitly accepting the legitimacy of the status hierarchy's foundation; and creativity through its dependence on existing "top dogs" to acknowledge the legitimacy of some reinterpretation of the comparative situation. Thus, there is good reason for someone who believes that the state faces a condition of status immobility to oppose these three responses. If the rules seem to be fundamentally unfair, then playing the game according to the rules will not only be futile, it will also reconstitute the rules, the game, and the unjust social hierarchy these produce.

Instead, the condition of status immobility leads to pressure for a response that *rejects* the status quo order. A response aimed at rejection is distinct from one aimed at recognition in two ways. First, its immediate aim is not to convince relevant others to grant the state higher status – whether in the form of membership in a high status category or club or of status-linked rights and privileges. This, after all, is thought to be impossible absent some dramatic change in conditions. Second, it explicitly rejects playing by the rules of the status quo order. Undermining the rules and institutions that constitute the order would run contrary to the requirements of mobility, competition, or creativity; but a belief in status immobility is equivalent to a belief that the rules are hopelessly unfair – thus, rejection *values* undermining the foundation of the status quo order.³³ Table 2.1 summarizes the three logics of recognition and contrasts them with the logic of rejection.

Research in the field of social psychology shows that individuals tend to support actions that reject status quo rules, norms, and institutions when faced with unjust, persistent denial of status. There is evidence to support this notion from both laboratory experiments and observational studies in a variety of substantive contexts. Beginning in the middle of the 1980s, a series of related studies (called the Five-Stage Model or FSM

³³ See Zarakol (2011), Kindle locations 2460–2610 on the fundamental difference between trying to advance within a social hierarchy and rejecting the order as distinct logics of identity management.

Table 2.1 *Logics of Identity Management*

Logic	Description	Nature of Solution
Mobility	Aims to gain entry into elite club by emulating its members' norms and institutions	Recognition by relevant others of new hierarchy
Competition	Aims to achieve higher status through geopolitically competitive practices	Recognition by relevant others of new hierarchy
Creativity	Aims to achieve higher status by changing collective understandings about what constitutes a status marker	Recognition by relevant others of legitimacy of new status criteria and new hierarchy
Rejection	Aims to protest, delegitimize, or overthrow status quo norms, rules, and institutions	Removes obstacle to achievement of status ambitions; expresses frustration, anger, resentment; avoids indignity of participation in own humiliation

studies) investigated individual emotional and behavioral responses to varying perceptions of the justice and flexibility of status hierarchies. Researchers manipulated individual beliefs about whether their placement in a low status group was just, as well as whether the higher status group was open to new members. Participants could choose to respond to their condition with “normative” action – for instance, accepting their placement or requesting a re-assessment of their individual merit for membership in the higher group; or they could choose a “non-normative” action – for instance, protesting their placement in the lower status group. Subjects were told that “non-normative” responses were seen as “unacceptable” to the members of the high status group. Results of these studies suggest that individuals facing a condition in which a high status group seems to be “closed” – especially those who believe they deserve membership in that group – are particularly likely to prefer “non-normative” behavioral responses. This may be due to consequentialist reasoning: if accepted practices leave no path to status advancement, then these practices must be circumvented or undermined. But it may also be due to affect: results of the FSM studies suggest an association between the perceived closure of the high status group and feelings of frustration and resentment – especially for subjects who felt they were better qualified for membership in the high status group.³⁴

³⁴ Taylor and McKirnan (1984); Taylor et al. (1987); Wright et al. (1990); Kawakami and Dion (1995); and Boen and Vanbeselaere (1998, 2000).

Observational studies – mostly conducted within the relative deprivation (RD) research program – provide additional evidence of a link between perceptions of persistent, unjust status denial and support for actions that reject status quo rules, norms, and institutions. Relative deprivation refers to a condition of perceived injustice: an individual believes that he or she suffers from some sort of deficit, not relative to what is needed for survival, but rather relative to a reference group or expectation-level. The experience of relative deprivation has been linked to a wide range of “non-normative” behavioral responses. For instance, in one of the most famous applications of relative deprivation theory (RDT) to a question of interest to political science, Ted Gurr invoked relative deprivation as part of an explanation for rebellion. Others have more recently noted a particular link between “collective relative deprivation” – that is, the belief that a group with which one identifies suffers collectively from RD – and protest “orientations” among members of disadvantaged groups within states, as well as support for “secessionist” or separatist movements.³⁵ The political scientist Justin Gest has extended a similar argument to the context of American and British politics and found compelling evidence that support for “anti-system” political parties in the United States and the United Kingdom is driven by perceptions among members of the white “working class” of “relative social deprivation” rooted in lost status in domestic class and racial hierarchies, along with pessimism about the prospects for future gains.³⁶ Again, there are multiple potential explanations for these findings, but researchers working within the RDT research program tend to focus on affect: the emotions of frustration and resentment that arise from the experience of collective relative deprivation are the proximal causes of “separatist attitudes and engagement in collective protest actions.”³⁷

What do these findings mean for international relations? Status immobility is, in part, a form of collective relative deprivation: it is a belief that the state with which one identifies does not enjoy the position that it deserves. Moreover, status immobility denotes a belief that the state’s status ambitions are incompatible with the status quo order – that there are no “normative” pathways that are likely to successfully alleviate the situation. For some individuals, this condition may not seem particularly

³⁵ For prominent early articulations of the RDT framework, see Runciman (1966) and Walker and Pettigrew (1984). See Gurr (1970) for the application of RDT to the study of revolutionary movements.

³⁶ Gest (2016).

³⁷ Abrams and Grant (2012), p. 4; see also Dube and Guimond (1986); Walker and Mann (1987); Grant and Brown (1995); de la Rey and Raju (1996); Grant (2008); and Stekelenburg (2011).

significant: there are surely more important things for many Chinese people to worry about than whether China is receiving its due in international politics. But for committed nationalists – “high identifiers” in the parlance of social psychology – the state’s status has deep significance for self-esteem, and the condition of status immobility demands a response.³⁸

The social psychological research discussed above suggests that that response is likely to take the form of some sort of rejection of the international order’s rules, norms, and institutions.³⁹ There are two ways in which rejection might seem to be an effective or satisfying reaction to the experience of persistent, unjust status denial. The first is based on the notion that overthrowing or revolutionizing the status quo order might destroy whatever element of the system is obstructing the satisfaction of the state’s status ambitions. This is akin to the argument that protest or secession movements are motivated by the desire to fundamentally transform an institutional order in a way that removes the source of injustice or deprivation. In the context of domestic politics, the ultimate manifestation of this drive is armed revolution: if the system is so corrupt that reform is impossible, then blowing it up is a necessary step toward a better future.

In the context of international politics, the desire to destroy a status quo order in order to rebuild it may – but does not have to – motivate a preference for hegemonic war. The objective of such a war is not to achieve membership in a high status club. Launching a major conflict against the most powerful defenders of the status quo is a counterproductive way of securing admission to their ranks via recognition. Rather, the point of a hegemonic war fought to “revolutionize” an international order is to remove some element of the order that seems like an impediment to the satisfaction of the state’s status ambitions. This might involve destroying the power of an actor or constellation of actors whose influence seems to prevent others from granting recognition; or it might involve demonstrating the bankruptcy of an institution or principle that seems to be the source of the state’s status immobility.

The drive to overthrow or revolutionize an international order represents a gamble that destroying the order will also destroy an obstacle to the satisfaction of the state’s status ambitions and thereby facilitate a

³⁸ The degree to which individuals identify with a group is a key intervening variable in research on social identity. See, for instance, Branscombe and Wann (1994); Doosje, Ellemers, and Spears (1995); Ellemers, Spears, and Doosje (1997); Spears, Doosje, and Ellemers (1997).

³⁹ Though Zarakol’s (2011) argument is not pitched in social psychological terms, she concurs with the notion that perceived obstacles to status advancement lead to responses that reject international order. See especially Kindle locations 2594–2610.

better future. This function does not *have to* be performed violently – states may be able to weaken or undermine status quo institutions through diplomacy, by intentionally sabotaging them through habitual norm violation or withdrawal, or by the construction of parallel institutions. And it is also worth noting that the link between overthrowing the old order and establishing a better one does not need to seem reasonable from the perspective of an objective analysis of costs and benefits in order for a frustrated nationalist to genuinely *believe* that it is a reasonable (and perhaps the *only* reasonable) response to the condition of status immobility. This is especially the case when the frustrated nationalist's valuation of the status quo itself is particularly low – that is, when the status quo seems intolerable. Thus rejection may seem attractive to some frustrated nationalists because it simultaneously represents action to undermine an unacceptable status quo and the possibility of securing a more satisfying future.

Rejection may also seem attractive for a second reason. Just as individuals can be motivated to protest or support separatist movements as means of expressing frustration and resentment with status quo institutions, a foreign policy aimed at rejection might seem attractive to a frustrated nationalist for reasons related to affect and emotion, rather than consequence and calculation. Rejection – whether it takes the form of violent conflict, a withdrawal from an institution, or a policy that explicitly ignores and invalidates international rules and norms – is a way of lashing out against the status quo order. It constitutes a salient signal that the state does not accept the legitimacy of some set of arrangements.

This is likely to be emotionally satisfying for a frustrated nationalist whose state seems to face the condition of status immobility for two related reasons. First, doing nothing may seem to amount to a tacit acceptance of the situation. Remaining fully engaged in the very institutions that appear to be perpetuating the state's status deficit might seem humiliating or threatening to an actor's dignity. Thus, protesting through some form of rejection – via withdrawal, rule-breaking, or in some other way – at least prevents the state from participating in its own humiliation. Second, rejecting status quo rules, norms, and institutions may be attractive as a means of actively expressing the negative emotions – anger, frustration, resentment – that are generated by the experience of status immobility. In short, rejection functions here less as a way of changing the prevailing order than as a way of managing its social and political consequences for the dissatisfied state.⁴⁰

⁴⁰ This is in the spirit of Zarakol (2011) and Adler-Nissen's (2014) conception of ways of dealing with imposed "stigma" through strategies that may not remove the stigma but rather manage its negative social consequences.

Two caveats are in order. First, the consequentialist and emotional elements of rejection are likely to overlap in practice – that is, when an individual expresses a preference for a foreign policy of rejection, he or she may very well do so for both of the reasons discussed in the preceding paragraphs. They are analytically distinct, but in practice they reinforce each other. And, as social psychologists know, disentangling emotional and practical motivations for protest is inherently difficult.

Second, I do not assume that policies or leaders are ever actually motivated by the social psychological dynamics described above. The argument so far is simply about the genesis of a certain type of policy preference – in favor of rejecting central elements of the status quo order – among a certain type of actor – strong nationalists – in response to perceptions of status immobility. No doubt some leaders are strong nationalists and are subject to the same kinds of dynamics. But this is not always the case. And even when it is, leaders also face incentives to pursue objectives that have nothing to do with the state's status, which often point in different policy directions. To draw a straight line from the social psychological processes that link status immobility to preferences for rejection among nationalists directly to policy leaves out critical parts of the story. Instead, I conceptualize the social psychological consequences of status immobility not (or, at least, not mostly) as a factor that directly motivates policy change, but rather as a factor that influences the domestic political environment that leaders and elites – both in and out of power – face as they compete over policy and position.

Status Immobility and Domestic Contests Over Foreign Policy

Leaders typically have to legitimate what they do – to provide public reasons in support of decisions and actions. But leaders cannot say whatever they want – public talk is constrained in various ways. It is constrained by the state's rhetorical environment – that is, by collective understandings about what kinds of things are appropriate and inappropriate to say; by the degree to which events seem consistent or inconsistent with a particular narrative or legitimation strategy; and by the speaker's institutional position. And since the limits of what can be legitimated impose limits on what can be done, these kinds of factors influence domestic political contests among elites and, ultimately, the direction of a state's foreign policy.⁴¹

⁴¹ On legitimation and rhetoric in foreign policy, see Krebs and Jackson (2007); Krebs and Lobasz (2007); Goddard and Krebs (2015); Krebs (2015b), (2015a); and Copenhagen School work on "securitization" (e.g. Williams [2003]).

This logic underlies an important mechanism through which status immobility influences foreign policy: it makes it harder to legitimate moderate foreign policies and easier to legitimate aggressive ones, especially policies that seem to reject status quo norms, rules, and institutions.⁴² Put concretely, widespread concerns about status immobility reflect and contribute to the production and prominence of discourses about the injustice of the status quo order. These make it harder to publicly justify participation in and respect for status quo institutions, rules, and norms, and easier to publicly justify policies that seem to lash out at the status quo. Status immobility has this effect for two related reasons.

First, dominant narratives or discourses – along with the policies that they make possible – can be undermined by the appearance of inconsistency with conditions or events.⁴³ In a rising state with unsatisfied status ambitions, leaders interested in pursuing moderate policies will have to explain how that course is consistent with the objective of achieving higher standing. This means making a plausible case that a patient, cautious approach that respects the rules of the status quo order and seeks to rise within the existing social hierarchy will pay off in the form of concessions from other states. The development of a prominent discourse of status immobility amounts to the development of the rhetorical material necessary to construct an effective counterargument against this claim. It can be invoked by *anyone* who opposes a moderate foreign policy – not just by proponents of rejection as a response to status immobility. Elites can make use of these resources to undermine the credibility of an incumbent leader for reasons of political ambition, or to promote foreign policy objectives that have nothing to do with status but that require that the cautious approach be undermined. Whatever the case, the more prominent and resonant is a narrative of status immobility – and the more easily its users can invoke foreign behavior as evidence of its validity – the more effective are the potential rhetorical and political weapons that can be wielded against an incumbent leader pursuing a moderate policy abroad.

Second, status immobility produces a natural constituency for actions that seem to lash out against the status quo order, and thus makes it easier to legitimate and politically beneficial to support aggressive policies – regardless of whether proponents of such policies care about status. A

⁴² For similar arguments about the international production of domestic political resources, see Snyder (1987, 1989); and Evangelista (1993).

⁴³ The idea that rhetorical possibilities are constrained by the degree to which events seem to line up with what an actor wishes to argue is obvious, but worth emphasizing. See also Legro (2005), Williams (2003), Goddard and Krebs (2015), Krebs (2015b).

militarist might, for instance, be interested in building a larger arsenal of some sort for reasons having nothing to do with status. Others might oppose such a policy because it would run afoul of some element of the rules, norms, and principles of the status quo order – perhaps in the form of an arms control regime – and thus provoke suspicion in foreign capitals. In a state characterized by a prominent discourse about the fundamental injustice of the status quo order, the militarist could fruitfully sell a violation of or withdrawal from the arms control regime as an act of rebellion against a rigged global hierarchy. This would engage the support of frustrated nationalists with preferences for acts of rejection. And – because of the dynamic described in the paragraph above – a moderate opponent would have a more difficult time defending the merits of playing by the rules than would be the case if there were not a widespread sense that the state's status ambitions were incompatible with the status quo order.

It is also, of course, possible that the political resources produced by discourses of status immobility might be harnessed by elites whose aggressive policy preferences *do* flow from the social psychological dynamics described above. But the theoretical account I develop is agnostic about the sources of the preferences of leaders and other elites. Status immobility makes it easier for *anyone* with aggressive policy preferences – regardless of their origins or motivational foundation – to undermine moderate leaders and policies and advance their own agendas, so long as they are willing and able to package them as or together with acts that seem to lash out against an unjust status quo.

Why would arguments in favor of an aggressive, rejectionist foreign policy couched in the language of status immobility not be effectively parried by moderate counterarguments based on pragmatic concerns about cost and risk? Sometimes, they may be. But recall from the discussion above that nationalists care about the state's status for reasons beyond its effect on security or wealth. This means that to legitimate any foreign policy to an audience made up of nationalists, a leader has to make a compelling argument that the policy is consistent with the pursuit or performance of the state's rightful place in the international hierarchy – that it is compatible with the nationalist vision of the state's place in the world. When status immobility is a prominent interpretation of the international context the state faces, it is difficult to package a moderate foreign policy – one that does not appear to reject or lash out against the status quo order – in a way that meets this requirement.

Moderates are left with two options. One is to deny that the state's status ambitions are incompatible with a moderate approach to revising the status quo – or attempt to demonstrate that they are not. This will be

less compelling the more prominent and widespread is the notion that some element of the status quo is fundamentally stacked against the state in question. Moreover, it may contribute to an even greater political advantage for hardliners, if attempts to prove the viability of a moderate approach to advancing the state's status raise expectations only to fail in the end.

The second option is to stress the other advantages of a moderate foreign policy: it may not help advance the state's status ambitions, but it could still promote trade and wealth, prevent isolation, and reduce the risk of unnecessary conflict. This effectively pits what analysts of rhetoric call an "epideictic" argument – one that involves questions about the state's identity – against a "deliberative" argument – one that involves questions about the best means of pursuing some objective. Put differently, status immobility-based arguments against moderate policy amount to arguments that doing something is incompatible with the state's identity; deliberative arguments to the contrary are arguments that doing the same thing is expedient. Analysts of rhetorical contests – including those working in IR – suggest that arguments based on identity claims often have an advantage over arguments based on expediency claims.⁴⁴ This is especially likely to be the case when nationalists – who should, all else equal, care more about status than others – represent a significant part of a leader's governing coalition.

Pathways to Policy Change and Exogenous Vulnerability

The two elements of the theory developed above – the social psychological and domestic political dynamics produced by beliefs and discourses about status immobility – can combine to influence policy through three distinct causal pathways, which are laid out graphically in Figure 2.1. In the first pathway (denoted by the checkered arrow), leaders themselves develop and act on preferences for rejectionist policies that emerge as a result of the social psychological consequences of status immobility. In an ideal-typical manifestation of this pathway, the domestic politics side of the story plays a limited role. This scenario is unusual for reasons laid out above. Leaders – even if they share the sensibilities of strong nationalists – have real responsibility for governing and thus have more than status to worry about. They also may be more sensitive than those outside the government to the concrete costs of pursuing rejectionist policies and to the benefits of restraint. Still, some leaders – for instance, as I show in Chapter 3, Kaiser Wilhelm II – do display evidence of being at least

⁴⁴ See Krebs and Lobasz (2007), p. 434; and Lawson-Tancred (1991), pp. 104–110.

partially motivated by the social psychological dynamics brought on by the perception of being unjustly denied status.

The other two pathways describe situations in which the elites in control of policy remain committed to a moderate, integrationist course and status immobility works by empowering their opponents. In the second pathway (denoted by the diagonally striped arrow), moderate leaders change course and adopt rejectionist policies against their own preferences because moderate policies become politically unsustainable. The specific form of political unsustainability varies according to institutional context – it may involve elite pressure in less open regimes and public pressure in more open regimes. In either case, the preferences of those outside power win out because moderate, integrationist policies become prohibitively difficult to defend.

The third pathway (denoted by the solid black arrow) is similar to the second but the mechanism of change is different. Here, moderate leaders do not respond adequately to demands for policies that appear to reject the status quo order, and are consequently replaced by leaders committed to pursuing a more radically revisionist approach. Depending on the state's institutional context, this could happen electorally, through elite negotiation, or through a coup.

Though these three causal pathways are analytically distinct, in practice they often overlap. Governments are often composed of groups of individuals who disagree amongst themselves about the state's strategic direction. When this is the case, different pathways can operate simultaneously – for instance, in the case of Wilhelmine Germany prior to World War I, there were hardliners within the government whose own aggressive preferences at least in part stemmed from status concerns, but there were also moderates who felt pressured by nationalists to pursue a more provocative foreign policy. And the second and third pathways may operate in sequence: moderates might initially be constrained by external pressure and then be replaced by still-dissatisfied hardliners. Nonetheless, for the purposes of theory building, it is useful to distinguish analytically between these three separate processes.

The extent to which these three pathways are likely to operate in different contexts depends in part upon another variable: the government's exogenous political vulnerability. Political vulnerability denotes the susceptibility of incumbent leaders to pressure from other domestic actors – for instance, from political opponents, interest groups, the media, or parts of the public.⁴⁵ But *exogenous* political vulnerability refers only to vulnerability that is not a consequence of dynamics associated

⁴⁵ On elite vulnerability, see Schweller (2006), Chapter 2.

with status immobility. Exogenous vulnerability may stem from a variety of sources – from institutional arrangements to economic crises to electoral defeats – that reduce the security, popularity, and legitimacy of an incumbent leader.

Exogenous vulnerability is not the focus of my argument, but it is worth flagging for attention because it influences the degree to and manner in which status immobility matters for foreign policy. When exogenous vulnerability is low – that is, when incumbent leaders are secure and mostly insulated from external political pressure – the second and third causal pathways described above are unlikely to be particularly significant. If status immobility matters at all, it will matter, by and large, via the first causal pathway: its direct influence on the attitudes, preferences, and actions of the leaders themselves.

As exogenous vulnerability increases, the relevance of the second and third causal pathways increases along with it. When leaders are more vulnerable to pressure from opponents and less secure from replacement by rivals, they will become more constrained by the need to placate various domestic constituencies – which may include frustrated nationalists clamoring for a forceful response to a status quo that they think is rigged against their state. Legitimation will matter more and be more open to contestation, and leaders will be more vulnerable to being overthrown by outsiders with different policy commitments. Thus exogenous vulnerability may enhance the potential influence of status immobility on foreign policy.

The historical episodes that I analyze in Chapters 3, 4, and 5 display different levels of exogenous vulnerability and – as a result – demonstrate the operation of different combinations of causal pathways. In each case, the social psychological and domestic political dynamics of status immobility contributed to a significant policy shift, but at a juncture during which leaders were vulnerable to external pressure in part for reasons unrelated to status immobility. Chancellors in Wilhelmine Germany were in some ways less institutionally vulnerable than were leaders in the Weimar Republic or Imperial Japan, but Bethmann Hollweg grew increasingly dependent upon nationalist conservative groups and the kaiser for legitimacy after the 1912 election made the Social Democrats the largest party in the Reichstag. This made him more vulnerable than he might otherwise have been to demands for provocative policies from groups like the Pan-German League. Still, the story of Wilhelmine Germany's shift toward radical revisionism is one that is as much (if not more) about the first causal pathway as it is about the second: many German leaders themselves (especially the kaiser) cared deeply about German status and resented what seemed to be British obstructionism.

This had serious consequences for German foreign policy apart from any domestic political pressure.

Exogenous vulnerability was higher in the other two cases. Combined with the fact that incumbent leaders in both Japan and Germany during the 1920s had moderate preferences, this means that status immobility's influence in these cases comes mostly through the second and third causal pathways. Moderate leaders in Imperial Japan became increasingly vulnerable to pressure from militant challengers due to the growing prevalence of threatened and actual assassinations, and in the wake of crises like the Great Depression and the Mukden Incident. This eventually helped make them responsive to nationalist demands that Japan leave the League of Nations. Incumbent leaders in the late Weimar Republic were very vulnerable to pressure from hardline outsiders. Much of this was endogenous to status dynamics, but some was not. Germany's dysfunctional government and the acute economic problems that struck after 1929 combined with anger and frustration related to the status implications of the Versailles settlement to destabilize the Weimar coalition and create the opening that Hitler jumped through to become chancellor in 1933.

Cases and Evidence

Empirically assessing theoretical accounts of international political phenomena often involves – at least in part – demonstrating the existence of a constant conjunction between causal and outcome phenomena: variation in the theory's independent and dependent variables must be correlated in the direction the theory implies they should be. This sort of analysis is popular in both quantitative and qualitative work: in the former, it appears as large-*n* regression analysis, while in the latter, it aims, in some form, to specify and observe within a small number of cases the presence of patterns of evidence – typically including a correlation between causal and outcome variables – predicted by various theoretical explanations.⁴⁶

The theoretical argument that I have developed above has characteristics that complicate and reduce the value of the search for a correlation between status immobility and radical revisionism. The most obvious problem is that the theory's central causal variable – status immobility – is difficult to quantify in a way that is valid across time and space. Status itself is notoriously hard to quantify. Scholars have attempted to do so

⁴⁶ See, for instance, King, Keohane, and Verba (1994); and George and Bennett's (2004) discussion of "congruence" tests.

through the use of data on “diplomatic exchange,” based on the theory that higher status states tend to be more attractive hosts for diplomats from abroad.⁴⁷ Diplomatic exchange, though, is a problematic way to measure the global status hierarchy. It is driven by a range of non-status factors (for instance, geographical proximity); it is strongly related to the material capabilities of the state sending representatives abroad, which means that diplomats from the highest status states in the system (which should, in theory, be the most meaningful) are the most common and thus convey relatively little information about the status of the states that host them; and data coverage is inconsistent.⁴⁸ Moreover, even assuming that diplomatic exchange does a reasonably good job of proxying status (which is an open question), a measure of status immobility would remain out of reach: this requires interrogating beliefs and discourse regarding the plausibility of achieving some ambition within the constraints of the status quo order.

Another complication is that the theory does not imply that there should necessarily be a straightforward association between status immobility and change in foreign policy. This is because of the central roles that path dependence, exogenous vulnerability, and agency play in the theory. First, the process through which beliefs and discourses of status immobility emerge and influence political contests is path dependent – it is easier to interpret foreign behavior as evidence of status immobility the more this has been done in the recent past, and vice versa (which is why, in Figure 2.1, the relationship between interpretations of foreign behavior and beliefs about status immobility is reciprocal). This means that we should not expect a straightforward conjunction between acts of status denial and the pursuit of revisionist policies, or between acts of accommodation and the pursuit of moderate policies.⁴⁹ Second, regimes vary in the degree to which they are vulnerable to political opposition: strong regimes may be relatively unaffected by critiques of foreign policy rooted in status immobility, but this can change rapidly if events conspire to increase the regime’s vulnerability. Third, the choices of individuals – leaders and political elites – are critical. Status immobility can be a potent political and rhetorical resource, but in order to exert influence on outcomes, individual human beings have to fashion it into an effective assault

⁴⁷ For descriptions, see Singer and Small (1966) and Small and Singer (1973); for recent applications, see Renshon (2016, 2017), Miller et al. (2015), Bezerra et al. (2015).

⁴⁸ The second problem means that Renshon’s (2016, 2017) recent effort to improve the diplomatic exchange indicator by weighting hosted diplomats more heavily the higher the status of the state that sent them has the effect of increasing the empirical leverage of the least informative observations.

⁴⁹ On the methodological implications of path dependence, see Bennett and Elman (2006).

against moderate policies and their proponents. Taken together, these characteristics of the theory depict a model in which policy change happens not continuously but in fits and starts, and in which the timing of change is difficult to predict. Evidence related to correlation or congruence between independent and dependent variables is unlikely to be particularly illuminating.

Instead, I evaluate the theory by looking for evidence that the processes developed above operate in ways that contribute to concrete shifts toward radical revisionism in the foreign policy orientations of rising great powers.⁵⁰ This strategy raises two questions: first, what counts as evidence in favor of the operation of status immobility theory's processes and mechanisms? Second, in what cases should we look for such evidence?

The first question calls for an articulation of status immobility theory's observable implications. When we investigate shifts away from moderate, distributive revisionist foreign policies toward radical revisionist foreign policies, what kind of evidence would indicate that status immobility played a significant role? Three kinds of evidence are important. First, there should be evidence that at least some prominent political actors – leaders, elites, or opinionmakers – believe or talk publicly about the existence of an unjust, insurmountable obstacle to the state's status ambitions. Establishing the presence of status immobility requires first establishing that the state's foreign policy expresses status ambitions, which is straightforward because these are often publicly articulated by leaders and elites in the course of legitimating or arguing over foreign policy. Whether this is purely instrumental or reflects real beliefs is inherently difficult to determine, but also not crucial, since the appearance of talk about status indicates at the very least the presence of a discursive environment that requires or rewards it.

How do we know the difference between a concern for status and a concern for some other good, like security or wealth? One clue is to look for evidence that actors are concerned about rights and justice in the state's foreign relations. A claim to status is fundamentally – and concretely – a claim to a particular role identity along with a claim to the rights that the role implies. To seek status is to seek the role identity and set of rights that the state deserves on the basis of its characteristics and accomplishments. When actors speak in terms of the rights that the state is owed on the basis of its position, they are articulating a claim to status.

Of course, actors may speak the language of status in support of policies that they really care about for other reasons. This is still evidence that actors find it politically beneficial to invoke unmet status ambitions – in

⁵⁰ On process-tracing, see George and Bennett (2004).

doing so they simultaneously reflect and reinforce expectations about the state's proper place in the world and the role of a particular policy in securing it. But to strengthen the claim that a state's foreign policy is at least partially motivated by status ambitions, I adopt a strategy familiar to analysts of status in IR: I show that at least some elements of the state's foreign policy that evidence suggests are attributable to status concerns cannot be explained by ambitions for security or wealth. This involves considering both the actual consequences of particular actions – whether they benefited the state's economic or strategic condition – as well as the reasoning of actors who argued for and against them.

But evidence of status immobility is distinct from evidence that a state is pursuing status ambitions. To ascertain the existence of status immobility, I look for evidence of people – whether leaders, political elites, members of the media, or parts of the public – interpreting foreign behavior as confirmation that the system is rigged against their state. This involves articulations of pessimism about the possibility of being treated fairly, as well as evidence of beliefs and discourse about the source of the obstacle – for instance, the presence of a prominent argument about national discrimination or the unfairness of a particular institutional arrangement. Again, this sort of talk may be entirely instrumental; this does not reduce its evidentiary significance, given the import of legitimization in the theoretical framework.

The second kind of evidence that supports the theory relates to the link between status immobility and preferences for policies aimed at rejecting status quo norms, rules, and institutions. The theory implies that nationalists should develop preferences for rejectionist policies as responses to status immobility. To evaluate this element of the theory, I investigate the objectives and motivations of individuals and groups who demanded radically revisionist policies – policies aimed at protesting, withdrawing from, or overthrowing status quo norms, rules, and institutions. The key question is whether these policy demands seem to have been motivated by or framed in ways reflective of the social psychological link between status immobility and rejectionist impulses developed above. This may take one or both of two forms: an argument in favor of overthrowing the order as a gamble aimed at removing the obstacle to the state's status ambitions; and an argument against participation in key elements of the order to avoid the indignity of being complicit in the state's own humiliation. The presence of one, both, or some combination of these arguments in the record of what revisionists thought or said as they developed and articulated demands for rejectionist policies constitutes evidence in support of the theory.

The theory's third set of observable implications relates to the domestic political consequences of status immobility. The theory suggests that

status immobility can influence policy by contributing to the abandonment of moderate positions or the fall of moderate leaders. This implies that we should find evidence that 1) moderate leaders understand the value of participating in status quo institutions, following status quo rules, and cooperating with states identified as status quo defenders; 2) proponents of more provocative policies – regardless of where these preferences originate – frame arguments against moderation in terms of the impossibility of achieving just treatment within the status quo, and benefit politically when foreign behavior seems to confirm these fears; 3) when moderates pursue or accede to policies favored by hardliners (and especially policies valued and promoted by hardliners for reasons related to the logics of rejection), they do so for reasons at least partly related to pressure from domestic hardliners or to the fear of a domestic backlash; and 4) hardliners are strengthened politically – and moderates weakened – by conditions that make more resonant and sustainable the argument that the state faces an unjust, insurmountable obstacle to recognition of its proper place in the world.

As well as investigating the observable implications of status immobility theory itself, it is also important to consider its role alongside other potential drivers of shifts toward radical revisionism. It is entirely possible that there might be plentiful evidence that the processes at the heart of the theory operated, but that they made little difference to the outcome. In other words, evidence that status immobility produces preferences for rejectionist policies and helps hardliners is not evidence that status immobility matters much relative to the causal factors highlighted by alternative approaches. My response to this problem is not to argue that these other factors – like power, domestic political dynamics, and ideology – do not matter at all. Indeed, the theoretical framework developed above acknowledges that they do. Nor do I attempt to assess the relative “causal weight” of these explanatory phenomena. Instead, I identify critical, concrete episodes during which foreign policy shifted visibly and significantly in the direction of radical revisionism, and ask whether these specific episodes can be adequately explained by prominent existing approaches. By demonstrating that they cannot – and then by showing that status immobility can make sense of these episodes – I establish that status immobility was an indispensable part of the process by which the states I examine abandoned moderation and moved toward broadly challenging the status quo order.

The second question that my empirical strategy raises is related to case selection. The theory’s scope, as developed above, is limited to rising powers – states in which growing material capabilities produce rising status ambitions and expectations but, simultaneously, incentives

for caution in foreign policy. Given my focus on process evidence, investigating the full universe of cases is impossible and unnecessary. Generalizability – not selection bias – is the most important case-selection problem for a study whose logic of inference is based on causal process observation rather than on controlled comparison. This concern places a premium on selecting cases whose features maximize the ability to argue that the study's findings have significance beyond their boundaries.

In the chapters that follow, I analyze three cases in which rising powers launched broad challenges against the status quo order: Wilhelmine Germany, Imperial Japan, and Weimar/Nazi Germany. These cases are valuable for two reasons. First, they are the paradigmatic examples of rising power revisionism in modern world history. The development of each state's foreign policy orientation began with a moderate approach championed by leaders who understood the value of participating in status quo institutions, playing by the rules, and aiming not to provoke other great powers. In each case, the moderate course was challenged by hardliners and ultimately abandoned in favor of a course that was significantly less concerned with demonstrating restraint. In other words, these three cases embody the puzzle at the core of this book: why do rising states, which have incentives to behave cautiously, sometimes adopt foreign policy orientations that challenge the foundation of international order?

Only two other cases of revisionism in foreign policy come close to the depth and significance of these: Revolutionary France and the early Soviet Union. Revolutionary France is an interesting case, but its turn against the status quo order *preceded* its rise to power. This was not a case in which a rising state that had incentives to behave moderately ignored them, but rather a case in which a domestic revolution – prompted in part by overextension and economic crisis – produced international conflict for ideological reasons. Similarly, the Soviet case does not provide an appropriate context for assessing a theory about why a rising great power would turn against the normative foundation of the status quo order because the period during which it most clearly did so came in the immediate wake of the Russian Revolution, not during a sustained period of increasing wealth and power. Both of these cases importantly remind us that there are potential causes of radical revisionism other than the status concerns of rising powers. In this book, I do not claim to have discovered a necessary condition for broad challenges against the status quo order. But both of these cases fall outside the scope of the theory developed in this chapter.

The second reason for analyzing these three cases is that other prominent theories already claim to explain most of their important features.

Wilhelmine Germany's turn against the status quo is frequently invoked by structural realists as a paradigmatic case of either opportunistic hegemony-seeking or preventive war.⁵¹ Imperial Japan's turn against the status quo is, similarly, often invoked as a case of overexpansion driven by domestic political dysfunction.⁵² Nazi Germany's revisionism seems easily explained by ideological distance.⁵³ What this means is that these are three hard cases for status immobility theory. Demonstrating that the processes described above play critical roles in foreign policy shifts that seem well explained by other factors should increase our confidence that status immobility may matter in other cases as well.⁵⁴

My focus in these three cases is on analyzing the origins of perceptible, concrete shifts away from moderate, distributive revisionist policies toward radical revisionist policies. Wilhelmine Germany's policy orientation changed around 1912 from one focused on seeking "world power" status to one that expressed a deeper dissatisfaction with the status quo order. In this case the change is subtle, but visible in German leaders' increasing willingness to contemplate overthrowing the European balance of power (which was, during this period, not just a geopolitical characteristic but also an important status quo institution) and decreasing willingness to openly cooperate with the British (who were identified as a defender of the status quo order), submit issues affecting their vital interests to ad hoc conference arbitration (another important institution of the pre-World War I status quo order), and back down during crises. This shift is the focus of Chapter 3.

The Japanese and Weimar/Nazi shifts are more easily identified because the interwar order was characterized by a set of formal institutions. Japan's foreign policy shifted between 1931 and 1933 from a distributive revisionist approach aimed at increasing Japanese economic and military power and status by working within the Western status quo order to a radical revisionist mix much less concerned with respecting status quo norms, rules, and institutions. The most obvious concrete rejectionist policy came with Japan's withdrawal from the League of Nations in 1933, and this is the focus of Chapter 4. Weimar/Nazi Germany's foreign policy began to shift away from Stresemann's moderate attempt to achieve piecemeal revisions to the Versailles settlement even before Hitler became chancellor in 1933. But once Hitler took over, German foreign policy – like Japanese foreign policy – became significantly less concerned with respecting the norms, rules, and institutions of

⁵¹ See Mearsheimer (2001), p. 188; and Copeland (2000), Chapters 2 and 3.

⁵² See Snyder (1991), pp. 120–150. ⁵³ See Haas (2005), pp. 107–109.

⁵⁴ For a discussion of this sort of "critical" case selection logic, see Eckstein (1975).

Table 2.2 *Summary of Cases and Evidence*

Rising Power	Timing of Shift	Aspirational Status	Outstanding Rights Claims	Source of Beliefs about Immobility	Elements of Order Challenged	Foreign Policy Consequences
Wilhelmine Germany	Post-1911	World Power	Equality in naval arms; compensation for territorial adjustments	British objection to German fleet; Anglo-French collusion (Morocco Crises)	Institution of the balance of power; ad hoc conference system	Inability to cooperate openly with British; willingness to contemplate war to reorder system; unwillingness to use conferences
Imperial Japan	1931–1933	Great Power	Equal treatment of population; sphere of influence; equality in naval arms	Racial discrimination; Lytton Report	Interwar security institutions	Withdrawal from League of Nations; withdrawal from Washington conference system; increasing influence of militants
Weimar Germany	1929–1933	Great Power	Sovereignty; self-defense; administration of territory abroad	Sluggish Western adjustments to Versailles settlement	Interwar security institutions	Rise of Hitler; unilateral rejection of Versailles restrictions; withdrawal from the League of Nations
United States	No shift	World Power	Sphere of influence in Western Hemisphere	None (ambitions accommodated after 1895)	No sustained challenge to British-dominated order	Accommodation failure could have contributed to stronger American opposition to British policy during the Second Boer War and World War I

the interwar European order. Germany withdrew from the League of Nations in September 1933 and subsequently took a number of other provocative steps. My focus in Chapter 5 is primarily on explaining how Hitler – who obviously had deeply aggressive foreign policy ambitions and is indispensable to any account of Nazi Germany's foreign policy – emerged as a viable alternative to the mainstream German right.

I also investigate, in Chapter 6, the case of the Anglo-American power transition. This is a negative case – the rising United States had clear, outstanding status ambitions but did not experience a shift toward radical revisionism. It is the best modern example of a peaceful power transition. While the case is different in important ways from those that are the focus of Chapters 3, 4, and 5, I argue in Chapter 6 that the processes at the heart of status immobility theory could have had a significant influence on American foreign policy, had American status claims not been effectively accommodated by the British beginning in the decade before the turn of the twentieth century. Table 2.2 summarizes the critical elements of the four cases that I examine in the chapters that follow.